



PADAUNG

THE LAND OF THE GIRAFFE WOMEN

THE PADAUNG PEOPLE OF BURMA number less than 7,000, but have attracted much interest over the years due to their practice of neck-stretching. The women, commonly known as “giraffe women,” start a life of neck rings at the age of five or six. The village medicine man works the first several loops around the girl’s neck at this age and then one extra is added every two years until the desired length has been reached. By the time the woman is of marriageable age, the neck will have extended to about 10 in (25 cm). The custom is more than a rare, strange expression of feminine beauty—the number and value of rings indicates status and respect for the wearer’s family.

